START WITH SOMETHING YOU CARE ABOUT

Two Countries Shared Questions

How do decisions in different places affect people our age?

Start with human and children's rights as November 20, Canada's National Child Day, approaches. Choose two countries and a question that matters to you; use stories, maps, evidence and news to investigate.

Name _____ Working with _____

What would you investigate

Everyday question	Possible focus
Can everyone get to school and take part?	Schools, transport, disability access, gender and money
Who gets a say in decisions?	Government, rights, young people and media
Where does our stuff come from?	Clothing, food, technology, workers and trade
How can people and wildlife share space?	Land, water, jobs, Indigenous rights and conservation
What happens when people move?	New homes, growing cities, services and belonging

Circle one that interests you, or suggest your own. You can change your question as you learn.

One question I would really like to answer

_____

_____

How we will work

Explore short class challenges → choose a focus → investigate both places → follow a news story → explain what you found.

You can talk, sketch, write or use agreed tools to show your thinking. You will find and compare sources in class, with help when needed. You do not need to share personal or family experiences.

Our goal: understand people and decisions, not choose a "best country."

PLAN YOUR INVESTIGATION

Choose your places and question

Country A _____ Country B _____

Choose places you are curious about. Try a search for each; ask for help if sources are hard to find or read. A country can include many communities with different experiences.

My question about BOTH places

_____

_____

Try: “How do people in ___ and ___ make it easier for children to ___?” or “How do ___ and ___ respond to ___, and who is affected?”

Find them on a map

Use an atlas or classroom map. Sketch or attach a locator map showing both countries, their continents and a nearby ocean. Add a key. Mark any city or community you will study.

Map source _____ Key _____

Why does this question matter to people

_____

_____

Something I think now that I need to check

_____

Teacher check: question and search plan ☐ Adjust with help ☐

A fair chance to take part

Imagine two children who want to join a school robotics club. These examples are invented.

Mina	Leo
The club is free, but her bus leaves before it starts.	He can stay late, but his family cannot afford the materials.

Would “everyone is welcome” solve both problems? What could help

Poverty means not having enough resources to meet essential needs. Inequality means people have unequal access to opportunities or resources. Money and social class can affect access; unfair rules about gender can create barriers too.

Human rights belong to all people. Children share these rights and need extra protections as they grow. Rights are not rewards for good behaviour. The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) sets out governments’ responsibilities to children. [1, 4]

Rights lens: fair treatment without discrimination; protection from harm; education, health and basic needs; a voice in decisions that affect you. Choose one to investigate. A written promise is not proof of daily experience. [1]

What can a number hide

Invented survey: in each place, 100 children were asked whether they could join an after-school activity that term.

Place	Could take part
River Town	80 out of 100
Hill Town	60 out of 100

Circle the supported claim: A. All River Town children are happier.
B. A larger share of the children surveyed in River Town could take part.

What would you ask next about the children who could not take part

Which right connects to our countries? What barrier will we investigate

[1] UNICEF child-friendly CRC; [4] UNICEF, What are human rights? Links: page 15 and teacher guide.

Who gets a say

A city needs a new transport plan. Who should make the decision? Who should be heard? Start with these simplified examples, not real countries.

Decision A	Decision B
People choose representatives in a fair election. Residents can question the plan and criticize leaders without punishment.	One leader chooses the plan. Residents have no meaningful way to replace that leader or challenge the decision.

What difference could these systems make to the people affected

In a democracy, people have a meaningful role in choosing leaders and holding them accountable. In an authoritarian system, power is concentrated and political freedoms are limited. Real systems need closer study; a label alone does not show how rights work.

Monarchy and republic describe a different feature: the position of head of state. A constitutional monarchy can be democratic; a republic is not automatically democratic.

Investigate a real decision

Choose a decision connected to your topic. Find sources for both countries; ask for help when needed.

Look for	Country A	Country B
Who decides?		
How can people influence or challenge the decision?		

Whose voice might be easy to miss? How could we learn from them

How are children heard in decisions affecting them? Look for evidence, not just a written rule. Experiences can differ within the same country.

Why people move

Migration is moving to live in another place, within a country or across borders. Urbanization is a growing share of people living in towns and cities. People move for many reasons, sometimes by choice and sometimes because they must.

Follow a fictional family

A farming family has had several poor harvests during dry years. One parent finds work near a city. The family moves there. Their new home is closer to a hospital, but rent is high and the school is crowded.

What pushed them to leave? What attracted them to the new place

Name one opportunity and one challenge after the move

A city has choices

More families arrive. The city can improve buses, build homes, expand a school or protect a green space. There is not enough money to do everything at once.

What information would you need before recommending a priority

Connect to our countries: where are people moving, and why

Use a source or class example. Write “still checking” if you do not yet know. Nobody needs to tell their own family’s migration story.

The journey of everyday things

A product can connect people in several countries before it reaches us. This is an invented example, not the history of a particular shirt.

COTTON GROWN → CLOTH MADE → SHIRT SEWN → SHOP → WORN OR REUSED

Each stage uses people's work, resources and transport. Countries may import goods they buy from elsewhere and export goods they sell elsewhere. This can create jobs and choices, but benefits and costs may be shared unequally.

If a flood stops cloth production, who else in the chain could be affected

_____

_____

Trace an object you care about

Choose an item, food or material linked to your countries. A "made in" label may show only one stage. If you cannot verify a connection, use your teacher's class example.

Our item _____ Source _____

Sketch its journey. Label places you can verify and put a question mark beside gaps.

How could this connection benefit people in BOTH countries

_____

_____

What concern about workers, prices or the environment needs checking

_____

_____

A low price alone cannot tell us how workers were treated. Find evidence before making that claim.

Land water and responsibility

Decisions about forests, rivers and oceans affect jobs, living things, cultural places and future generations. Indigenous Nations have their own rights and responsibilities concerning their lands and waters.

Two real examples

Haida Gwaii, Canada. The Council of the Haida Nation describes Watchmen caring for village sites and teaching visitors about Haida heritage. The program is supported by the Parks Canada Gwaii Haanas field unit. [2]

Whanganui River, Aotearoa New Zealand. Ngā Tāngata Tiaki o Whanganui explains the river as an interconnected living whole, with the people and river inseparable. Its account describes Whanganui Iwi responsibilities for the river’s well-being. [3]

These are short summaries of the named sources. They describe particular peoples and places, not everyone in either country.

What shared responsibility do you notice? What is different

Investigate a resource decision

Choose land, water or a resource connected to your topic. A policy is a rule or plan that guides decisions, such as where fishing or building is allowed.

What decision is being made, and what benefits and harms are being considered

Which Indigenous Nation or representative organization is relevant? What does its own source say

If you do not yet have a relevant source, ask for help. Do not invent a viewpoint or treat a Nation as simply a charity.

[2] Council of the Haida Nation, Haida Gwaii Watchmen. [3] Ngā Tāngata Tiaki o Whanganui, Tupua Te Kawa. Links in teacher guide.

A problem that crosses borders

Fictional case: two countries share a river. During a dry year, the upstream country plans to store more water for its farms. Downstream communities worry about drinking water and fish. Both countries need food and jobs.

What is causing disagreement? How could money or resources influence decisions

A conflict is a serious disagreement; some conflicts become violent, but disagreement does not have to lead to war. Conflict can happen within a region or between countries. Cooperation means working together toward a shared goal.

Who could help and how

People or group	Possible role in this fictional case
Residents and young people	Explain daily needs, ask questions and suggest changes.
Governments	Make rules, negotiate and provide public services.
An NGO	An organization outside government could research, support communities or advocate for change.
An international organization	Could help countries share information or negotiate.

Where Indigenous lands or rights are involved, the relevant Nations and rights-holders must be part of understanding the decision. Their role is distinct from that of an NGO.

Suggest a first step that considers people on BOTH sides of the border

What could make your plan difficult? What might happen if it fails

Real-world link: with your teacher, examine an age-appropriate example of regional or international conflict. Compare its causes and a peaceful response with this case.

LEARN THE ROUTINE BEFORE FOLLOWING A STORY

Be a news detective

A headline is a starting point. Read, listen or watch the whole item you find or explore in class before deciding what it means.

Same event different headlines

Invented event: a town replaces 20 parking spaces with a protected bike lane. A student says cycling feels safer. A shopkeeper worries about deliveries. The town will review the change after three months.

A. Town makes room for safer cycling
B. Town takes away parking from local shops

What does each headline emphasize? Write a fairer headline

_____

_____

Pause and check

1. WHO and WHY? Name the author or organization. Inform, persuade or sell?
2. WHEN? Check the event date as well as the publication date.
3. WHAT supports it? Look for evidence, not just a strong opinion.
4. WHOSE VOICE? Are affected people, including children, heard? Is privacy protected?
5. WHAT ELSE? Compare another source. What agrees, differs or is missing?

A factual claim can be checked. A fact is supported as true by evidence. An opinion expresses a judgment. An inference is an explanation you draw from evidence and may need to test. One report can contain all three.

Mark each statement F for checkable fact, O for opinion or I for inference

___ The town replaced 20 parking spaces.
___ This is the best decision the town has ever made.
___ More students may cycle because the route feels safer.

News can inform us, but wording, pictures and repeated posts can shape what we notice. A widely shared claim is not automatically true.

Follow a news story

Country or place _____ Date viewed _____

Story title _____

Reporter or organization _____

Published _____ Event date _____ Link or class source code _____

What happened

Explain the main event in two or three sentences, or use a labelled sketch.

One checkable claim and the evidence given for it

A person or group heard in the story, and what matters to them

A voice or fact I would still like to hear or check

How does this connect to our country comparison

Look again later: new information, a correction or a changed view

Find a suitable story using class search guidance. Compare who made it and why. Ask for help with disturbing content or tricky sources; a class or printed example is an option.

Find evidence for your question

Our question _____

Focus for this page _____

Ask the same question about both places. Which right is involved? Compare written promises with evidence of people's experiences. Give each source a code such as A1 or B1.

Country A _____	**Country B _____**
Evidence in my own words	Evidence in my own words
Who or where? When?	Who or where? When?
Source code and page	Source code and page

Both places _____ but _____ differs

_____

_____

Why does this matter to people

_____

_____

Comparing numbers? Match what is measured, the unit and the year. "Out of 100" can help. Different dates need a note; missing data do not mean zero.

Keep your source trail

On a separate source sheet or class document, record each code, author or organization, title, date, exact link or book/page, and data year if needed. Your teacher can provide source labels to attach.

Look beyond one story

A country includes many experiences. Find people within one country whose access to a right differs, such as across regions or communities. Use evidence; do not rank whole countries.

The example and its source

_____

_____

Listen before you explain

Person community Nation or group	What the source says matters to them
Name and source	View or priority
Name and source	View or priority

Where do their views connect or differ? What might explain this

_____

_____

Use “The source says…” for a stated view and “I think… because…” for your inference. Do not speak as if you represent the group.

Then and now

Earlier date _____	Later date _____
What happened or was different?	What changed or stayed the same?

One cause or consequence to explain, with evidence

_____

_____

Was the effect expected? Who benefited, and who faced difficulties?

BRING YOUR EVIDENCE TOGETHER

Build an answer and a next step

Our answer to the question

Our strongest evidence from BOTH places and its source codes

Something that changed our thinking, or a limit to our answer

What could people learn from one another

An idea worth considering and what might need to change in a different place

Plan a realistic response

Choose a response linked to your evidence: explain an issue to classmates, suggest an improvement, ask a useful question or propose a small school action.

We propose _____ because our evidence shows _____

Who should help or give permission? One possible benefit and one possible problem

This page is a plan. Check with your teacher before contacting anyone, collecting money or sharing work outside class.

PRESENTATION AND REFLECTION

Share what you discovered

Choose a format with your teacher: a poster talk, slides, a tabletop exhibit, a recorded explanation or another accessible format. Everyone should be able to explain the main comparison.

Help your audience follow your thinking

☐ Show the two places and your question.
☐ Explain a meaningful similarity and difference with evidence.
☐ Use a news example and more than one perspective; explain a connection to rights.
☐ Show a change over time or explain a cause and consequence.
☐ Give your answer, one limit and a sensible next step.
☐ Credit your sources and give your audience something to think about.

Our question or small activity for the audience

_____

_____

Try it with a classmate

Ask: “What did you learn? Where did you need more explanation or evidence?”

One revision I will make after feedback

_____

_____

My own learning

I used to think _____. Now I think _____ because…

_____

_____

A contribution I made and one idea I can explain using evidence

_____

_____

You can reflect in writing, audio, a labelled visual or a teacher conversation. Clear thinking matters more than decoration or confident public speaking.

Places to start your search

You can search beyond this list. No website tells the whole story: check the author, purpose, evidence and date, then compare another source. Ask for help with difficult or upsetting content.

Rights, country facts and data

UNICEF — Children's rights

Child-friendly CRC: connect a right with your question, then investigate how people experience it.

https://www.unicef.org/child-rights-convention/convention-text-childrens-version

National Geographic Kids — Countries

Maps and introductions to places. Use these to get started, not as the only view of a country.

https://kids.nationalgeographic.com/geography/countries

UNICEF Data — Country profiles

Compare information about children. Ask for help with charts; check the year and what each measure means.

https://data.unicef.org/country/

News to investigate

Teaching Kids News

News written for young readers. Check publication dates and look for another account of the issue.

https://teachingkidsnews.com/

CBC Kids News

Another place to look for news and explanations. If access is unavailable, try another source or ask for help.

https://www.cbc.ca/kidsnews/

Perspectives from people and communities

Council of the Haida Nation — Haida Gwaii Watchmen

Read the Nation's own account of caring for village sites. This connects with page 7.

https://www.haidanation.ca/hg-watchmen

Ngā Tāngata Tiaki o Whanganui — Tupua Te Kawa

Explore a Whanganui Iwi account of the river and responsibilities. Some words may need discussion.

https://www.ngatangatatiaki.co.nz/our-story/tupua-te-kawa/

For your own places, look for relevant Nations, community organizations and people speaking for themselves. Identify whose perspective each source offers; do not treat it as everyone's view.

Follow class search guidance. You do not need a new account, purchases or personal details. Ads and search rankings are not proof that information is reliable.